

so" smile I got from my father when I informed him that, having retired at 24, I was coming out of retirement at 26!

In 1919, oilmen's attention was already shifting from Oklahoma to Southern California, where new producing areas were being discovered and developed. A great new Oil Rush was in the making, and I was among those who wanted to be in on it from the beginning. My initial oil-prospecting venture in Southern California was a fiasco: I drilled my first California well on the Didier Ranch near Puente, but the well proved to be a dry hole.

The luck that had stayed with me in Oklahoma had taken a brief holiday, but it hadn't deserted me.

Subsequent tries were considerably more successful. I drilled several wells in the Santa Fe Springs, Torrance, Long Beach and other Southern California areas, and most of them proved to be producers, some of them sensational producers.

I spent most of my time in the field working on the drilling rigs with my men, a habit which paid many handsome and unexpected dividends. Not the least of these stemmed from the drilling crews' reactions to the presence of a working boss on the job. The men felt they were partners with the boss in a mutual effort, rather than merely employees of some corporation run by executives they never saw and who had probably never set foot on a

12

drilling platform in their lives. Morale— and production—

soared as a result.

This was important, for with new wells being drilled by the hundreds throughout Southern California, there was an acute shortage of experienced oil-field workers. The personnel managers of most large companies engaged in wild scrambles to find the necessary manpower for their operations. They bid frantically against each other in the labor market, offering special inducements and benefits to anyone who'd ever had any experience working on an oil rig. Most old-timers resented the implication